



SLOVAKIA

Capital city: Bratislava
Area: 18,859 sq miles (48,845 sq km)
Population: 5,400,000
Official language: Slovak
Major religions: Christian 72%, other 28%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Euro
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 73 years
People per doctor: 278
Televisions: 402 per 1,000 people

Distribution of lumber and mining



INDUSTRY

Today, one-third of the workforce has jobs in industry, as Slovakia fights for a place in the industrialized world. But the large industries set up by the former communist rulers have been difficult to break up. Some of the major Slovak industries include metallurgy and metalwork (which counts for 33% of all their industry), chemistry, and the alimentary industry, which is industrial production of food. Much of eastern Slovakia is still forested, so logging and papermaking are also important.

Spis Castle is a national monument and is one of the largest castles in Central Europe.



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ONCE THE EASTERN PART of Czechoslovakia, this small, beautiful country is much more rural than its highly industrialized neighbor, the Czech Republic. When Czechoslovakia broke free of Soviet control in 1990, the Slovaks felt they were being dominated by the wealthier Czechs and campaigned for independence, which came in 1993. The Slovakian economy was hit hard by the split because it relied on Czech money and resources. In this mountainous land, the Slovak population is divided between different valleys, and the country lacks a geographical focus. Most people speak Slovak, but various dialects are still spoken in the more isolated areas.

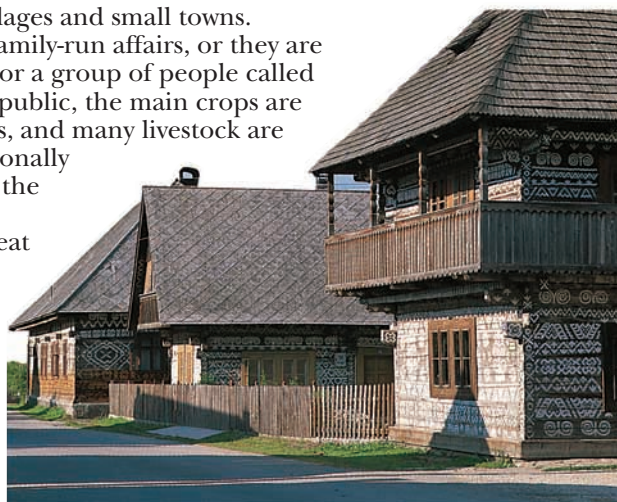
The castle used to control the mine revenues.



VILLAGE LIFE

This is a country of mountain villages and small towns. Slovakian farms are either tiny, family-run affairs, or they are large businesses run by the state or a group of people called cooperatives. As in the Czech Republic, the main crops are potatoes, sugar beets, and cereals, and many livestock are kept. Although Slovakia is traditionally rural, only a small proportion of the population is now employed in agriculture. There has been a great drive to develop industry, and many people are moving from the country to the towns.

Traditional wooden houses in Cicmany, Slovakia



UNSPOILED LANDSCAPE

The natural beauty of Slovakia's countryside gives it huge potential as a tourist destination as long as it remains unspoiled. Here are stunning mountain landscapes, castles perched on rocky outcrops, ancient walled towns, and mineral-rich spas. Great efforts are being made to develop the tourist industry, since there are as yet few facilities for visitors.



BRATISLAVA

This city is one of the youngest capitals in the world – it became the new capital of its new country in 1993. This former residence of an archbishop has been made into the Presidential Palace. Bratislava is the only large city in Slovakia and historically has good links with Austria and Hungary. However, the city's good communications and modern industry have helped attract interest from foreign investors.

BANSKA STIAVNICA

As early as 1156, the term "terra banesium" (land of miners) was used to describe the region. Around 1237 Banská Stiaavnica achieved legal status as a town, making it the oldest mining town in Slovakia. Then, in 1735, the first mining university in Europe was founded here. Ironically, economic stagnation in the 19th century, which halted the town's development, has led to a valuable tourist revenue in the 21st century, as the plan and architecture of the town have remained intact.

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